



Homegrown talent: Mikel Gonzalez, Athletic Club's sporting director, takes pride in the club's 'Basque-only' philosophy, which selects players of Basque origin. SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT / LA LIGA

focusing on high-performance management. "We have made five verticals: medical, physical conditioning, nutrition, sports science, and psychology. For example, suppose we do not have enough centre-backs in the first team. Our only option is to improve the players on the B or C teams. So, one of these six or seven players has to be our next centre-back. They have specifics to work on. Physically, tactically, and so on. So, we train to improve the players in these areas. Even if they improve one percent, it makes a difference for us," says Gonzalez.

Tweaking its century-old method has been an unwelcome proposition among Athletic's top brass and 45,000-strong members, even in the face of an impending demographic

shift. The Basque Institute of Statistics had predicted that the region's population would decline by nearly five per cent between 2013 and 2023. In addition, the Basque country's average age was 45.6 years in 2023, two years more than Spain's average. Similarly, only 19% of its population was 19 or under in 2023.

But Athletic would rather be a struggling club with an identity than a successful club without one. "I do not see this happening. I am also one of those 45,000 members. For me, philosophy is the essence. Being unique guarantees our success," says Nerea Oritz, Athletic's vice

president.

For a club that has carved a space for itself in the elite league over the past 125 years, the questions over the policy and its validity hold a familiar tone. But the players, the fans, and the management work single-mindedly to stay true to their beloved philosophy.

"This question, 25 years ago, was the same. We thought it would be impossible to play in La Liga because the clubs are investing a lot and taking players. It was the same 50 years ago," says Gonzalez.

The correspondent was in Spain at the invitation of La Liga, recently



Athletic has established a feeder line for its first and second teams through its youth academy in Lezama. This academy has tie-ups with 160 local clubs, ensuring that it never runs out of talent.